

Line of WORRY

India fears Islamabad may use the political flux to derail the Mumbai attacks investigation

| By Saurabh Shukla |

As Pakistan teetered on the brink of collapse last week, the worry lines across India's forehead deepened. With major political fissures opening up, rising extremist violence, vast swathes of land slipping out of Government control and into Taliban hands, the army and the ISI up to their old tricks of backing terror groups, Pakistan in recent months had become a nightmare for India. So when the crisis blew over with President Asif Zardari capitulating, the Pakistan Army resisting a chance to take over and Nawaz Sharif emerging as a key power centre, South Block heaved a sigh of relief. "It's good that Pakistan's crisis has been resolved peacefully. A stable

Pakistan is good for the stability of the whole region," said Pranab Mukherjee, India's external affairs minister.

India's laundry list of worries remains—with no clear power centre, who to do business in Pakistan with? Is it the civilian Government led by Zardari or his Prime Minister Yousaf Gilani or is it Pakistan Army Chief General Ashfaq Kayani? India has often talked about a multiplicity of power centres in Pakistan and the current stand-off has only reinforced that impression. Kayani continues to hold the remote control of power but there has always been a question mark on the Pakistan Army's willingness to control terrorism directed against India. Analysts too believe that this may be a tough time for India. "The Pakistan Army has become stronger and will exercise greater control over Pakistan and we should be prepared for more terrorist attacks," warns former Indian envoy to Pakistan G. Parthasarthy.

For India, the biggest worry is having a nuclear-armed neighbour that has become a one-stop shop for terrorism and extremism, besides the fear that the terror threat may only expand in the run-up to the elections.

Alarm bells have started ringing in the country following recent intelligence reports that point to an increase in terrorism from across the border. "Intercepts indicate that Pakistan-based terror groups plan to target key political leaders in the run-up to the elections. There is

TALIBAN SUPPORTERS
IN SWAT AFTER THE
PEACE PACT; KASAB
(RIGHT)



AP PHOTO/SHERIN ZADA

